FREE CARDS

My Circles: Boundaries Map

A hands-on circles activity: who is in my circles, and what touch, talk and sharing fits each one.

WHO IT IS FOR
Autistic children and young people, with the teachers, SNAs, parents and carers who teach them.

NCCA STAGE
Primary · Junior Cycle · Senior Cycle and LCA

Easy read

I have circles of people. Some are close. Some are far. Different circles get different touch, talk and sharing.

How to use this resource

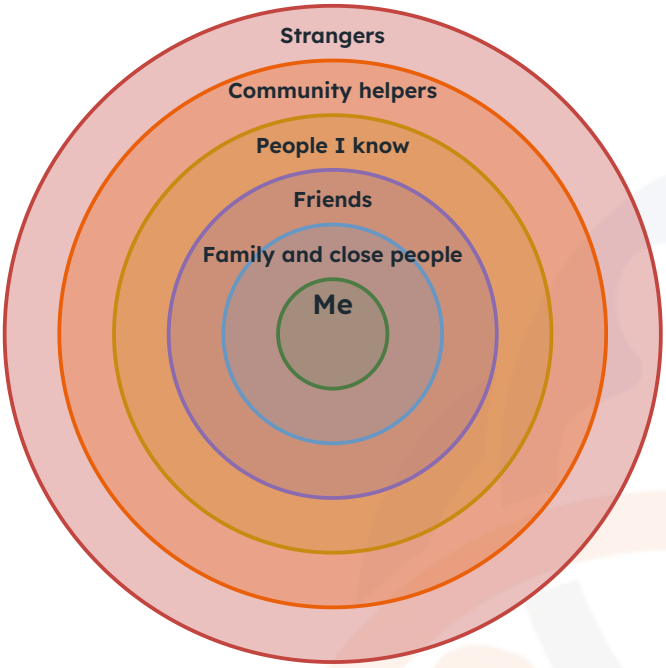
- Start with the circles map on page 2. Read each circle and talk about the people in it.
- Cut out the people cards on pages 4 and 5. Place each card on the circle where the person belongs. Stick in photos if you like.
- Follow the 40 minute lesson plan on page 6.
- Remember: circles can change. And a person in a close circle can still do something that is not OK.

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Version 1.0 · my-circles-boundaries-map

My circles map

I am in the middle. The people closest to me are in the circles near me. People I do not know are in the outside circle.



Me
My body is mine. I decide who touches me and shares my things.

Family and close people
Touch: hugs if I want them. Talk: private things, feelings. Share: private things, with care.

Friends
Touch: high-fives, hugs if both want. Talk: hobbies, feelings. Share: what I like, not private things.

People I know
Teachers, coaches, SNAs. Touch: handshake or high-five if I want it. Talk: school, sport, help. Share: only what I need.

Community helpers
Doctor, shopkeeper, bus driver, Garda. Touch: only for care or help, with explanation. Talk: polite. Share: only what they need.

Strangers
People I do not know. Touch: none. Talk: only if I need help. Share: nothing private, ever.

I am in the middle. My body is mine.

Closer circles get more. Farther circles get less.

Strangers get no touch and no private information.

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What fits each circle

Circle	Touch	Talk	Sharing
Me	My body is mine. I choose.	I can say how I feel.	I choose what to share.
Family and close people	Hugs if I want. Care like washing or dressing, explained first.	Feelings, worries, private things.	Private things, with care. Never secrets that make me feel bad.
Friends	High-five, handshake, hug if we both want.	Hobbies, jokes, how I feel.	What I like. Not private body things. Not passwords.
People I know	Handshake or high-five if I choose. Help I ask for.	School, sport, help.	Only what they need.
Community helpers	Only to help or care, explained, with a trusted adult there.	Polite and short.	Only what they need, such as my name at the doctor.
Strangers	No touch.	Only to ask for help.	Nothing private. No photos. No address.

Two important things

- **Circles can change.** A friend can become a close friend. A friend can stop being a friend. I can move a person to another circle if I want.
- **Someone in a close circle can still do something that is not OK.** Family, friends and people I know are not always safe. If someone makes me feel unsafe, I say stop, go away, and tell a trusted adult. Keep telling until someone listens.

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People cards: where do they go?

Cut out the cards. Place each one on the circles map. Stick in your own photos on the blank cards. Talk about your choices.



Mum or Dad

Which circle?

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My best friend

Which circle?

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A classmate

Which circle?

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My teacher

Which circle?

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My SNA

Which circle?

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My doctor

Which circle?

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Shop worker

Which circle?

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Bus driver

Which circle?

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Someone I have never met

Which circle?

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My own photo cards

Stick a photo of a person in each card, or draw them. Write their name. Place the card on your map.



Photo of a person

Name: _____ Circle: _____

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Photo of a person

Name: _____ Circle: _____

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Photo of a person

Name: _____ Circle: _____

© autismandme.ie



Photo of a person

Name: _____ Circle: _____

© autismandme.ie



Photo of a person

Name: _____ Circle: _____

© autismandme.ie



Photo of a person

Name: _____ Circle: _____

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Photo of a person

Name: _____ Circle: _____

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Photo of a person

Name: _____ Circle: _____

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Photo of a person

Name: _____ Circle: _____

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Teacher activity plan: My Circles (40 minutes)

Suitable for a class, a small group or one-to-one. For younger children, use 3 circles (Me, Family and friends, Everyone else). For older students, use all six and discuss online circles.



0 to 5 minutes: Welcome

Explain the aim: 'Today we learn about who is close to us and what is OK with each person.' Show the circles map.



5 to 10 minutes: Me

Start in the middle. 'My body is mine.' Ask the group: who decides about my body? (I do.)



10 to 20 minutes: Circle by circle

Go through each circle. Use the table on page 3. Ask for examples. Keep language literal.



20 to 30 minutes: Sorting task

Students place people cards on the map. Allow pairs, pointing, or photo cards. Accept different answers if they can explain them.



30 to 35 minutes: Not OK from someone close

Say: 'Even someone close can do something that is not OK.' Remind them of the rules: say stop, go away, tell a trusted adult, keep telling.



35 to 40 minutes: Wrap up

Each student names one trusted adult. Recap in one sentence: 'Different people get different touch, talk and sharing.'

Notes for adults

- Use the students' own people and photos wherever possible. Abstract circles are harder than named people.
- Do not ask students to name people they are afraid of in front of the group. Offer a private chat afterwards.
- Reassure students there are no wrong circles. If a student places someone in a different circle from you, ask why before correcting.
- Some students have carers who do intimate care. Explain how that fits: it is for care, explained first, with agreed people, and the student's no still matters.
- Teach the online circles too: online friends are in the 'people I do not know' or 'stranger' circle until a trusted adult has checked. No private photos or information go online.
- If a student tells you something worrying, listen, believe them, do not promise secrecy, and follow Children First (2017). In school, tell the DLP the same day.

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Curriculum links

NCCA and Department of Education alignment

- Primary SPHE (1999), strands **Myself** and **Myself and Others**, strand units *Safety and protection* and *My friends and other people*; Stay Safe programme.
- Junior Cycle SPHE (2023), Strand 1 **Understanding Myself and Others** and Strand 3 **Relationships and Sexuality**.
- Senior Cycle SPHE: new specification published 2024, being introduced for fifth years. LCA: Social Education.
- NCCA guidance on RSE for students with special educational needs: use concrete, visual activities with real people and photos.

Universal Design for Learning

Every Autism & Me resource offers more than one way in: pictures and words together, an easy-read line, things to do with your hands, and scripts to practise. Keep the learning aim the same for everyone, and change the route. No diagnosis is needed to use any support in this resource.

Getting support in Ireland

Emergency

112 or 999 — Gardaí, ambulance or fire. Use it if someone is in danger now.

Childline (ISPCC)

Free, 24 hours: phone 1800 66 66 66, text 50101, or chat at childline.ie. For anyone under 18.

Tusla – Child and Family Agency

Report a worry about a child's safety to your local Tusla social work duty team. Contacts at tusla.ie.

Parentline

Support for parents and carers: 01 873 3500, parentline.ie.

Webwise

Online safety advice for parents, teachers and young people at webwise.ie.

Your school

Talk to the Designated Liaison Person (DLP) for child safeguarding, a class tutor or year head.

Autism & Me

Questions about this resource or training for your school: contactautismandme@gmail.com · autismandme.ie

If a child tells you something worrying

Stay calm. Listen, and believe them. Do not promise to keep it a secret. Write down what they said in their own words, with the date. Pass it on the same day: in a school, to the Designated Liaison Person (DLP); otherwise to Tusla. If anyone is in immediate danger, call 112 or 999. Follow *Children First: National Guidance for the Protection and Welfare of Children* (2017).

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